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Napoleon Perpetuated the Goals of the Enlightenment as a Power-Hungry Tyrant

Napoleon Bonaparte seized power in a coup d'état and conquered most of Europe. He was raised during the French Revolution and came to prominence after successfully defending the National Convention in 1795. After additional battlefield victories, the popular military leader took control from the Directory of France in 1799 and established himself as the first consul. The ambitious absolute ruler was eventually defeated after making a series of costly mistakes. Historians argue whether Napoleon perpetuated the goals of the Enlightenment as an enlightened revolutionary or if he undermined them as a power-hungry tyrant. The goals of the Enlightenment were liberty, reason, nature, progress, and happiness. With freedom (i.e., liberty) to obtain newfound knowledge (i.e., reason), demystified nature can be harnessed to advance the human condition (i.e., progress), and pursue the striving of a worthy life (i.e., happiness). Napoleon, the “Philosopher-prince” (Bruun), used these ideals to his political advantage; the net effect of his ruling perpetuated the goals of the Enlightenment as a power-hungry tyrant through his reorganization of the government to promote efficiency, development of the economy and financial balance, and military conquests to spread radical ideas to the European countries.

Napoleon reconstructed France’s government with an emphasis on supporting the goals of Enlightenment. In 1799, Napoleon gained power and started his reign by eliminating corrupt officials and inefficiencies from the government that pre-existed in the Directory. Next, he created lycees in 1801, which were government-run public schools with a vision of producing

intelligently trained government officials. These two advancements exemplify the Enlightenment goals of reason and progress; they improve the government for the present and future of French society. Napoleon never believed in religion, however, he understood the Church's impact in France to spread the Enlightenment goal of happiness. Napoleon signed an agreement in 1801 with Pope Pius VII, called a concordat, to restore order in the church and resolve hostilities that remained from the French Revolution. It stated that the government would become secular, disempowering the Church, which, while further empowering the ambitious monarch, also allowed Europe's development through science and reason. An uncorrupt and nonreligious government would increase the ability for its society to demystify nature, and learn how the natural world works, promoting the enlightened goal of nature. The agreement also stated that there was no official religion in France which granted people their religious freedom to fulfill the Enlightenment goal of liberty. During this time, the French government was full of turmoil. Napoleon addressed this by establishing the Napoleonic Code. While this set of organized laws curtailed some freedoms of speech and press, it advanced the goal of liberty by reducing injustices. The people were willing to accept these sacrifices because, "more pressing than the demand for social equality or democratic institutions [...] was an intense aspiration for order" (Bruun). The major Enlightenment thinker, Thomas Hobbes, argued that it is necessary for people to give up their natural rights of freedom to the empowered leader, however, "the privileged and the unprivileged classes, philosophers, peasants, democrats, and despots all paid homage to this ideal" (Bruun). The Napoleonic code provided them a sense of security and prevented anarchy to facilitate the goal of happiness and reason. Napoleon changed the government to not only increase his own power, but to also advance French society and promote goals of the Enlightenment.

Napoleon advanced the goals of the Enlightenment with the positive impact he had on France's economy. First, he established the Bank of France in 1800 and regulated the state's currency. This was an attempt to promote economic recovery and end a long-standing recession from the previous era. Napoleon's way of promoting structured financial management spread progress, reason, and happiness throughout society. He supported the idea of giving more financial balance to the people of France. Napoleon established tariffs and loans, as "military preparedness and economic self-sufficiency were the cardinal principles" (Bruun) to strengthen France's progression. Napoleon added to the success of his economy by building and repairing roads, canals, and bridges which provided more job opportunities. He also abolished the old guilds and monopolies. Napoleon freed laborers by abolishing feudalism. This gave people their own sense of liberty as they could control their land reforms. Also, people were able to pursue new careers based on merit. Merit emphasizes the qualifications of a person rather than their social status. In fact, hereditary monarchies "who were born to the throne may get beaten twenty times and still return to their capitals" ("The Napoleonic Legacy" 489) while people under merit cannot, and instead have to work harder to sustain their legacy. Napoleon even acknowledged his own status resulted from the merit he earned after the French Revolution ended in 1799. Napoleon supported the cause of giving determined underprivileged people similar chances for success as the wealthier, entitled folks. The people of France were happy to have economic opportunity for such progress, which is a goal of Enlightenment.

In his rise to power, Napoleon fought and won many battles to broaden the idea of Enlightenment throughout the French Empire. Although the continuous campaigns that Napoleon led did not necessarily bring happiness to the people, it should be noted that he was not the one to initiate many of the early battles. Such examples would include in 1795, he defended

the National Convention against attack by rebels. In 1796, he was ordered to attack the army of Austria and the Kingdom of Sardinia. In 1799, Britain, Austria, and Russia joined forces and fought against France to thwart Napoleon's progression, prevent him from gaining further power, and stop the spread of his new radical ideals of the Enlightenment. These countries feared that “the conqueror's show of establishing representative government, equality before the law, individual liberty, and religious freedom provided peoples unused to them with a fleeting experience of a new and better order” (“The Napoleonic Legacy” 488). As the military head, Napoleon won these battles, triggering the spread of the ideals of Enlightenment to all the neighboring countries he conquered, giving reason to these wars. These victories prompted the other countries to sign peace treaties with France, and for the first time in ten years, peace prevailed throughout Europe. Napoleon's personal ambitions and “lust for glory that led him constantly to engage in dramatic actions for which there was little real rationale” (“A Time of Revolutions”) eventually went too far, bringing his downfall. In 1808, Napoleon was conquered and exiled to the island of Elba for a period of time. After managing to escape, he regained power in France again, replacing King Louis XVI who was despised by the people of France. The French cheered with joy after having their leader return, validating the happiness he brought to the people.

The net effect of the actions of Napoleon, “son of the philosophes” (Bruun), as a power-hungry tyrant perpetuated the goals of the Enlightenment through his modification of the government to reduce corruption and removal of Church, forward thinking to stimulate economic growth, and military actions which brought to light radical ideas of enlightenment across Europe. Under his rule, “feudalism was abolished, the estates of the Catholic Church expropriated [...] [and] unified codes of law based on the French model established” (“A Time of Revolutions”).

He did not unwind the Revolution's progress but rather "he rounded off its work" (Rudé) and advanced the human condition of the French Empire. In spite of his reputation as a power-hungry tyrant, Napoleon was revered by his people and progressed France forward into the new century.